

have something in writing that ensures that you have not been lied to. The presence of an evil co-pay clause has caused plenty of curses to fly in the direction of insurance companies when the glitzy promises of care turn into castles of sand at the time of a health crisis.

Two, ***check for a 'pre-existing' disease clause***. Insurance companies will not cover diseases that you already have when you take the policy. Insurance rules allow a company to refuse to pay for any treatment related to any condition, ailment or injury for which you were diagnosed or had symptoms when you took the policy, for four years.

For example, if you were diagnosed with kidney stones and took a policy soon after, the company is within its rights not to pay for the surgery to remove those stones if it happens in the next four years. But there are companies that waive or reduce this waiting period, to pay up earlier. Check to see how long the waiting period is in the policy you shortlist.

But a caveat here: People with any pre-existing disease find it difficult to get a cover. Some insurance companies use this clause to refuse claims for totally unrelated ailments. It is a good idea to disclose your correct present and past medical history to the insurance company when you sign up for the policy. Else they will have a tool in their hands to refuse your claim. And, believe me, they use it to refuse claims on very flimsy grounds.

One columnist for *Mint* documented how a pregnant lady was hospitalized for fever. Normally the fever may not have needed hospitalization, but because she was pregnant, she was admitted. The claim was rejected because ailments related to pregnancy are not covered in the policy.

Three, ***check if your policy has a 'disease waiting period'***. Many companies have a cool-off period of thirty to ninety days during which they will not pay any claim. Some ailments such as cataract or hernia may have a 'waiting period' before the company will pay. Ask the agent to list out all diseases that are covered under this clause. Look for a policy that does not have a waiting period on diseases or coverage.

Four, ***check if your policy has 'sub-limits'***. A friend was admitted for a knee surgery to one of Delhi's upmarket hospitals. Confident of a Rs 4-lakh cover, she selected a single deluxe room. When the time for the payout came, the